of the discomfort had been on top of the metatarsal, but that night the pain was all underneath my foot. It felt like the studs were pushing up into the injury every time I pushed down to run or strike the ball, twisting the fracture every time I tried to turn.

The pain in my foot didn't stop me enjoying the game, though. The first twenty minutes, especially, were fantastic. We played like we didn't have a care in the world, even in a winner-takes-all game at a major tournament. Five minutes in, I put over a corner. Rio got his head to it but nobody was sure until afterwards that he got the goal because the ball hit a post, then their keeper, and finally Emile Heskey jabbed it in again when it bounced back out. I even thought about claiming it myself at the time. But I'm really glad the video replays gave it to Rio. He's such a good guy to have in the dressing room and, out on the field, he had a fantastic World Cup. Getting on the score sheet was the least he deserved from the summer.

Fifteen minutes later, Michael scored the second and that seemed like game over. Denmark got themselves into some good positions but we went up the other end just before half-time and Emile got his goal. The heat had worn us down against Nigeria in Osaka. The rain was just what we'd needed in Niigata. It quickened the field up, which is something that suits the way Sven wants England to play. 3–0 was just fine, all anyone could have asked for. And against a team who'd qualified for the second phase at France's expense. I'd have been jumping up and down afterwards, celebrating advancing to the last eight, except my foot was killing me. By the end of the game, I'd been getting cramp in it because I was running with my boot angled to one side to try and take the pressure off the sole. The rest of me was in much better form, though. I felt fresher against Denmark than I had at any time since coming back from the fracture. And, afterwards, I had the satisfaction of knowing I'd been much more involved: I'd been part of the build-up to all three England goals.

So it was Brazil in the quarter-finals: win that game and we'll win the World Cup. I know, back home, people were starting to take it very seriously. England were contenders. In the past, high expectations have put pressure on the national team. In Japan in 2002, though, our supporters weren't thinking anything that me and the other players weren't already thinking ourselves. Argentina? Out. The defending champions, France? Out. Italy? Out. Portugal? Out. The Dutch? Not even there. Who was left in? Of the teams with a World Cup history, it came down to two: Germany, who we'd beaten 5–1 in Munich to get to the finals, and Brazil. We couldn't wait for Friday afternoon and Shizuoka.